THE THREE KEY PLAYERS

The three leaders involved in bringing a political solution to Manipur's ethnic clashes have not been able to find a common ground. Ironically, they all belong to the same party–BJP

AMIT SHAH
Union Home Minister



- Has been monitoring the state's law and order situation since the violence erupted on May 3
- Despite his three-day visit in May end and regular interactions with stakeholders, Shah has not been able to bring on board the state government, militant groups and civil society bodies from both sides–Meiteis and Kukis–to even begin a dialogue
- He is stuck between two extreme demands from both sides. While CM N. Biren Singh wants revocation of the Suspension of Operation (SoO) agreement with Kuki militants, the Kuki groups have set Biren's ouster as the primary condition to begin peace talks

N. BIREN SINGH
Chief Minister, Manipur



- A Meitei, he has been accused of siding with his own community. Kukis allege he has been intentionally targeting them and must be removed from the CM's chair
- Biren claims that Kuki militant groups instigated others and took part in violence; so the SoO agreement with them must be revoked
- When under pressure to quit, he made a display of his popularity among Meiteis as a massive crowd stopped him from resigning, even tearing his paper
- Sacking him may go against the ruling BJP as Meiteis decide the outcome in 40 of the 60 assembly seats

HIMANTA BISWA SARMA
Chief Minister, Assam



- Known for his persuasive skills, he is the unofficial chief interlocutor with various stakeholders, as even Kuki groups trust him
- But Meitei groups have become skeptical after the claim of a Kuki militant that Sarma had taken help from Kuki groups party to the SoO to make the BJP win in 2017 assembly polls and 2019 Lok Sabha polls. A complaint from Manipur BJP MLAs to the Union home ministry forced him to issue a denial
- On July 2, he met several Kuki leaders in Guwahati, in the presence of A.K. Mishra, MHA adviser (Northeast)

nity's historical sense of distance from the Meitei-controlled mainstream. So, when the CM raised the issue of "illegal immigration" of Kukis from Myanmar, citing their high growth rate, community leaders accused him of ethnic bias. And that's the reason they have declined to be part of any peace dialogue initiated by the Centre till Biren remains the CM.

But the Union government is unlikely to sack Biren, particularly after the resignation episode, as it could weaken the party's grip over the Meiteis, who decide the electoral outcome in 40 of the 60 assembly seats in Manipur. Biren has projected himself as a champion of the community by raising two key issues. One, the refugee influx of Kukis, which the Meiteis allege has resulted in "land-grabbing" in the foothills surrounding the Meitei-dominated Imphal valley, currently the theatre of the clashes. The other is the demand to revoke the suspension of operations (SoO) agreement sealed in 2008 to start a political dialogue with militant groups. On March 10, the state government unilaterally withdrew the SoO agreement with the Kuki National Army (KNA) and Zomi Revolutionary Army (ZRA), alleging that they were instigating people against the government drive to evict illegal encroachers from forest land.

Top BJP leaders fear ousting Biren at this stage could be perceived among Meiteis as a punishment for his action against the Kukis. That the Naga community—also tribals living in the hills like the Kukis—has remained neutral in this conflict also goes in Biren's favour.

But making matters worse for the BJP's central leadership is a public interest litigation (PIL) plea filed in a National Investigation Agency (NIA) court on June 8. The petitioner is S.S. Haokip, chairman of the United Kuki Liberation Front (UKLF), an armed organisation party to the SoO. The affidavit included a 2019 letter he purportedly wrote to Union home minister Amit Shah, claiming that his organisation and another Kuki outfit—the United Peoples' Front (UPF)—had helped BJP candidates win the assembly election under an agreement with Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma and former BJP Northeast in-charge Ram Madhav. The outfit allegedly also helped the party in the 2019 Lok Sabha election. In the